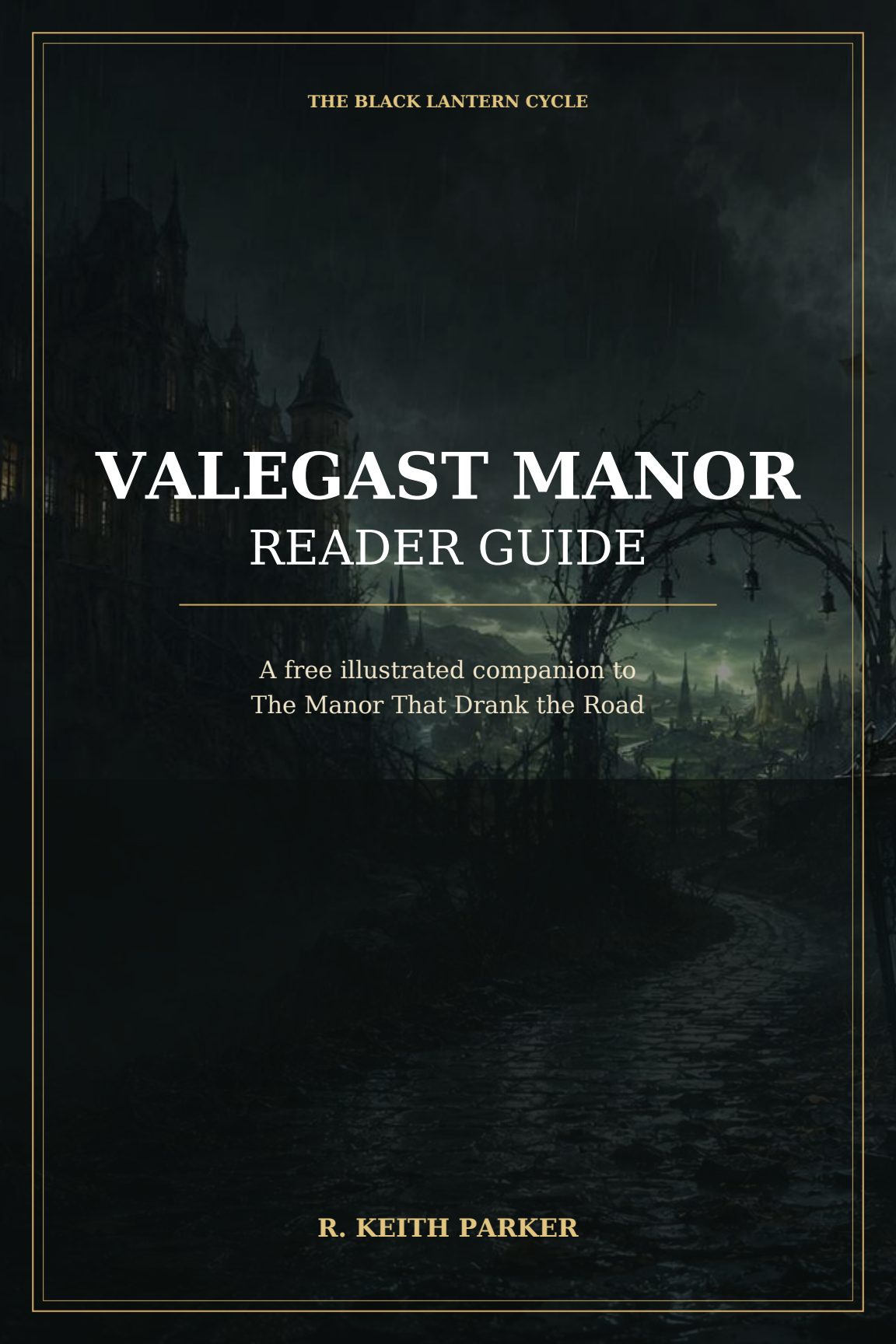




THE BLACK LANTERN CYCLE

VALEGAST MANOR

READER GUIDE

A free illustrated companion to
The Manor That Drank the Road

R. KEITH PARKER

Welcome to the Lantern Road

Dear Reader,

Thank you for finding your way to the Lantern Road. Valegast Manor is the first haunted threshold in The Black Lantern Cycle, and this guide is meant to be carried beside it: part map, part warning, and part witness record.

Inside you will find the official upper-level floor plans, five guest-laws worth remembering, a spoiler-light introduction to Cael Veyr and the Black Lantern, an opening excerpt from Book One, and a glimpse of the road that waits in Book Two.

The stories in this cycle ask what happens when kindness becomes an obligation, when grief is made useful to strangers, and when a house is allowed to write the law of everyone beneath its roof. The Lantern does not make those questions easy. It only makes them visible.

I hope Valegast stays with you long after the last door closes.

Walk carefully,
R. Keith Parker

Valegast Manor at a Glance



The first riderless horse returns in the rain. The third carries a seal from House Valegast.

Road-witness Cael Veyr follows the evidence to a manor where welcome is binding, breakfast is judgment, and every kindness can be entered as debt.

Place
The Eltwald March

Witness
Cael Veyr

Instrument
The Black Lantern

First warning
Never thank a house for opening its mouth.

FLOOR PLANS — UPPER LEVELS

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- A** EMPTY CHILD
PLACE-SETTING
Crumbs. Not NOT For RIL.
- B** FIFTH REMEMBERED DOOR
(CHILD-HEIGHT)
Always closed.
Not a servant's
door. Not for
adults.
- C** BLACK-GOLD
ROAD-SHADOW
The path beneath
breakfast.
Leads downward.

 GUEST BOOK
(RECORD OF
WITNESS)

NO DOOR UNSEALED.
ONLY WITNESSES.
ONLY RECORD.

Five Laws Every Guest Should Know

I

A welcome may become a debt.

A gift freely offered can still be entered into a house ledger as obligation. Ask who records the kindness and who benefits from the record.

II

Do not thank the house.

Gratitude can be heard as consent when the listener is older than the custom. Thank the person, if you must. Never thank the walls.

III

The third bell binds what the first two invite.

Repeated ceremony changes hospitality into judgment. Leave before a custom becomes the only law the room recognizes.

IV

A hidden name is still evidence.

When a guest is absent from the record, ask who had the authority to remove them and who was spared by the erasure.

V

A closed door is not proof of safety.

At Valegast Manor, the sealed threshold may be the most honest thing in the house. The open door is the one making a claim.



THE WITNESS

Cael Veyr

A road-worn witness who has learned that surviving a haunted law is not the same as answering it. His ash staff, carving tools, and Black Lantern are instruments of proof before they are weapons.

Road Without Return

The horse came back without its rider.

It came out of the rain at dusk, black from mane to fetlock, one broken rein dragging through the mud and a coach trace snapped against its flank. No blood showed on the saddle. No pack hung from the straps. No human voice followed it down the road. Only the horse. Only the rain.

Only the sound of hooves striking puddles in a measured, exhausted way, as if the animal had walked from a place where running had been forbidden.

Cael Veyr stood beneath the old toll stone and let the horse come to him. The stone had once marked the lower road into the Eltwald March, back when lords still counted wheels, hooves, sacks of grain, and men walking beside a cart. Most travelers take the bridge road now. The toll stone had been left to moss, old law, and birds that liked to watch from dead branches.

Cael had come because of the horse. More exactly, he had come because this was the third horse returned in six weeks, and the first two had carried no rider either.

Road Without Return

The first had belonged to a salt factor. The second had belonged to a chapel courier. This one had pulled the left side of a Kaltbruck coach carrying five named souls: a driver, a wool merchant, the merchant's wife, her younger brother, and a little girl with a blue ribbon tied around her sleeve so she would not lose herself in rain.

That detail had brought Cael to the toll stone.

The ribbon. People forgot whole households when roads swallowed them. They remembered ribbons. A color could outlive a witness. A thread could accuse longer than a tongue.

Cael knew that too well.

The Black Lantern burned in his left hand. Its flame was not large. It did not throw honest warmth. It sat behind blackened glass and burned the color of old honey until the horse crossed the line of the toll stone. Then the flame bent hard toward the animal.

Road Without Return

Cael tightened his grip. 'Easy,' he said.

The horse stopped three paces from him, heaving sides. Its eyes rolled white. Rain ran off its jaw and fell in long strings from the bit. The saddle was good mountain leather, recently oiled. The stirrups were a matched pair. One bent backward, not by a fall, but by pressure from below.

Cael did not touch the horse at once. Horses remembered roads better than men remembered promises.

He set the butt of his ash spear in the mud and raised the lantern until the dark flame could see the tack. The horse trembled. A leather strap near the left haunch had torn where a coach trace should not have been tied to a riding saddle. Someone had altered the gear in haste.

Cael lifted the strap with two fingers. A wax seal clung to the leather.

Road Without Return

Rain had softened it, but not enough to ruin the mark. Three narrow towers. A cup between them. A vine wrapped around the cup's stem.

House Valegast.

Cael had seen the mark once in an old road ledger from the southern tolls: a noble house of the March, old enough to owe no one an explanation and poor enough, supposedly, to take no guests except in winter charity.

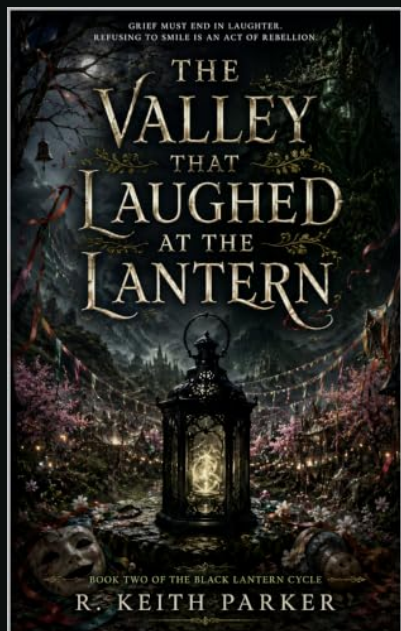
Winter charity had a taste in old records. Thin ink. Heavy praise. Missing names.

The horse jerked when the lantern flame leaned nearer. Cael lowered the light. 'I know,' he said. 'The house had you.'

What the House Wants You to Miss

- The seal
Three towers, a cup, and a vine. The mark of House Valegast appears before the house itself does.
- The ribbon
A small blue thread becomes harder evidence than the broad claims made by officials and ledgers.
- The guest book
A record can witness a wrong, hide a wrong, or become the instrument that makes the wrong legal.
- The breakfast table
Hospitality becomes dangerous when ceremony decides who may refuse, leave, speak, or remain unnamed.
- The Black Lantern
It does not erase the haunting. It reveals the agreement the haunting has been allowed to call necessary.

The Valley That Laughed at the Lantern



Book Two of The Black Lantern Cycle

A festival valley turns grief into public joy and calls it mercy.

Festival ribbons lead Cael into a valley where a grieving mother is required to smile over her child's coffin. When the Lantern exposes the Bright Passing as false record, Cael and grief-keeper Elyra Thornmere must make a beautiful mercy answer for its cost.

Available now on Kindle and Kindle Unlimited.

The Road That Laughed First

The road into the valley wore festival colors before it showed a single house. Ribbons hung from the branch-limbs over the lane, faded where old weather had worried them, but still bright enough to move like cheer in the wind.

Red. Saffron. Cream. Blue. Pink gone pale as watered blood. Small bells had been tied among them. They answered the morning in thin silver voices that should have sounded merry.

Instead, they rang with the patience of something practiced too often.

Cael Veyr stopped beneath the first of them and listened. The Black Lantern at his side gave no light while shut, but its weight seemed greater here, as if the metal knew before he did that the valley ahead had rules of its own.

The morning had the mild gold of late summer. Orchard country opened ahead in ordered slopes. Whitewashed walls shone through leaves. Pennants moved on distant poles. He smelled apples, crushed grass, sweet bread, and smoke.

Beneath those came the smell he trusted more. Fresh earth. Not the broad smell of farms. Not wet ditch or turned field. A narrow, recent opening. One grave, or something made with the same care.

Cael looked down the road again. 'No,' he said softly.

It was the first thing his mouth had learned to do after Valegast Manor: refuse the shape of welcome before welcome could close around him.



Continue the Lantern Road

Begin with *The Manor That Drank the Road*, then follow Cael Veyr into the haunted laws, borrowed names, and dangerous mercies of *The Black Lantern Cycle*.

START BOOK ONE ON AMAZON

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Thank you for carrying the light.